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Steve Neale

Mark Dixon discusses genre in relation to the set text *Tehran*.

Neale's theory, at its simplest, tells us that media products apply genre-driven codes, and that those same products might bend or subvert genre-driven expectations. Neale's thinking, as such, is hugely useful in media language exam questions that ask us to explore the importance of genre, or to diagnose how language use in products is shaped to create audience appeal. A perfectly satisfactory response to such questions might, in turn, identify the key genres used by products, offering analysis of moments where genre codes are obvious and repeat what has gone before. Better responses might discuss how media texts or products offer difference. Where, for example, it blends codes from different genres or offers genre hybridisation. Decent responses might argue that genre codes are subverted, for example, because audiences are easily bored by texts that simply reproduce well known genre tropes.

The Eduqas set text, *Tehran*, for example, principally recycles the tropes of the spy thriller genre. In narrative terms, *Tehran*'s use of escalating tension, its mission-driven story structure and conventional agent-hero-lead all paddle in the same direction as the *Mission Impossible* franchise or James Bond's never-ending quest to rid the world of foreign sounding bad guys. *Tehran*'s bad guy, Faraz, similarly, is easily decodable as the show's episode one villain – his role as an Iranian secret service antagonist constructed via the use of black costuming codes, canted angle compositions and an emotionally inert persona as demonstrated in the episode's early interrogation scene.

The design of the show's marketing material also piggybacks on other key texts in the genre. Its season two poster foregrounds the show's female spy lead in similar manner to the billboards used to promote the ground-breaking global streaming hit *Homeland*. Stylistically, too, *Tehran* foregrounds technology-oriented backdrops – an iconic mise-en-scène feature of spy thrillers – while the use of a percussion laden soundtrack punctuated by winnowing drones and scene climax bass-bomb are conventional sound devices used in thriller scores to drive tension and suspense.

A good Neale-style analysis of *Tehran* might also identify moments of difference, where, for example, the show constructs a humanised portrait of the Iranian populace via Tamar's surrogate husband; his concern for his wife's whereabouts constructing a more tender portrait of Iranian masculinity than that offered by Faraz. Iranian authority figures are identified here as the enemy, not the Iranian people.

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That sentiment is writ large using the conventions of realism – the long takes and low-key-lit ambience used to construct the family homes of everyday Iran present, interestingly, moments that are juxtaposed with the high-tempo chase sequence delivered at the end of the first episode.

We might also identify Moshe Zonder's role (the show's creator) in manufacturing difference and his auteur approach that foregrounds realism in his settings as another marker of genre difference. Zonder, for example, painstakingly recreated the authoritarian claustrophobia of Iran via carefully wrought set dressing, an aesthetic styling that is distinctly at odds with more conventional use of exotic/escapist settings in spy thrillers. Moshe Zonder's trademark approach to television making is clearly coloured by his experiences as an investigative journalist working in Gaza and the Arabic speaking countries that surround Israel. That experience coats his approach in *Fauda* (2015) and *Tehran* with a deeper realism than that found in *Bond* or *Mission Impossible.* As a result, one might argue that *Tehran*, potentially, reflects the political realities of the Middle East in ways that most conventional spy thrillers sidestep.

So far, so good. The above represents a fairly decent media language response that successfully applies Neale's ideas in *Tehran*. Examiners would give lots of ticks for the analysis provided above and also for the use of the subject specialist language. Marks, however, could be quickly levelled up if we talk about how media language and genre features are also driven by industry-oriented factors.

Neale, importantly, isn't just interested in media language applications. Yes, he's interested in how media products work and how they conform to specific genres, but he's also concerned to diagnose why products use or subvert genre codes. Neale, importantly, draws attention to the ways that media producers filter genre-driven ideas using a process that he labels institutional mediation.

Kan-11's role, for example, in commissioning *Tehran*, and subsequently Apple TV's adoption of the show exemplify that process and help to explain why *Tehran* is so sympathetic to the Iranian populace. Kan-11, importantly, are a publicly owned Israeli television broadcaster, not hugely dissimilar to the BBC in the UK, producing public service broadcasting for the Israeli domestic market. Kan-11 also pride themselves on producing material that seeks to inform as well as entertain Israeli audiences, leading many in Israel to suggest that they affect a liberal or left-wing bias in content. Indeed, that perception of bias is such that the current right-wing Israeli government headed by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has threatened to defund the organisation.

In this sense, Kan-11 potentially exemplifies the arguments of Curran and Seaton – that diverse funding produces diverse content. Their public service ethos, similarly, filters the use of spy thriller genre codes in *Tehran*, driving the narrative towards a more humanised representation of the Iranian characters depicted. The financing of season two by Apple TV, similarly, has reshaped that characterisation, with Hollywood heavyweight Glen Close cast in leading role to create global appeal – bending the narrative towards more conventional outcomes for commercial reasons.

So, you can see that there's more to a genre question that just identifying generic conventions. Understanding that industry, audience, representation and language features of media texts are all interlinked help us to be able to respond to the 'why' aspects of a genre-based essay and will hopefully help you achieve better marks in your exams.

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Questions to help you analyse genre more effectively:

- How do industry-based factors related to your television set texts affect representations issues or media language use?
- How do audience needs shape the representation created in your set texts? Who are the audience and how do their expectations shape how ethnicity or gender are presented, for example?
- How do genre-based character tropes shape the representations created in television shows? How do stock characters, for example, provide producers with ready-made representations of gender?